

Word family: **specific / specifically / specificity / specifics / nonspecific**

Base word: specific

Part of speech: mainly **adjective**, also **noun** in plural (**specifics**)

Related forms:

specific (adj.) — 具體的；明確的；特定的

specifically (adv.) — 具體地；明確地；特別地；專門地

specificity (n.) — 具體性；明確性；特異性

specifics (plural n.) — 具體細節；詳情

nonspecific / non-specific (adj.) — 非特定的；不具特異性的；籠統的

specify (v.) — 指明；明確說明

specified (adj./participle) — 指定的；已明確說明的

specification (n.) — 規格；詳細要求；說明

Useful expressions / extensions:

be specific

specific details

specific reason

specific example

specific person / place / time

specific to

specifically designed for

specifically mention

more specifically

the specifics

technical specifications

meet specifications

species-specific

task-specific

nonspecific symptoms

specificity

Meaning in this passage

> ...when it is honest, timely, and **specific**, it can really mend the situation.

Here, **specific** means:

clearly identifying exactly what was done wrong and what the apology is for — 具體的；明確指出問題的

A good apology does not merely say “sorry” in a vague way. It identifies the actual wrongdoing—for example, blaming someone unfairly and embarrassing them publicly.

****中文翻譯：****

只要道歉是真誠、及時而且****具體明確****的，就真的可以修補局面。

So here:

****specific = 不含糊，而是清楚指出確切的人、事、原因或行為****

1. ****specific (具體的；明確的) — 具體的；明確的****

This is the exact sense used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> A good apology should be honest, timely, and ****specific****.

好的道歉應該真誠、及時而且****具體明確****。

Practice 2

> Please give me a ****specific reason****.

請給我一個****具體理由****。

Practice 3

> Her feedback was very ****specific****.

她的回饋非常****具體****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specific = 清楚而準確地指出確切內容，而不是籠統或模糊****

2. ****be specific — 說具體一點；說清楚****

Practice 1

> Can you ****be more specific****?

你可以**說得再具體一點嗎**？

Practice 2

> Try to **be specific** when you explain the problem.

解釋問題時，盡量**說得具體明確**。

MCQ-ready definition:

be specific = 提供足夠明確的細節，而不是只作籠統描述

3. **specific detail — 具體細節

Practice 1

> The witness gave several **specific details**.

證人提供了幾個**具體細節**。

Practice 2

> Add **specific details** to make your answer stronger.

加入**具體細節**，可以令答案更有說服力。

MCQ-ready definition:

specific detail = 清楚、確切而非籠統的細節

4. **specific reason — 具體原因

Practice 1

> Is there a **specific reason** for the delay?

延誤有沒有一個**具體原因**？

Practice 2

> He couldn't give a **specific reason** for his decision.

他無法為自己的決定提供一個**明確原因**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specific reason = 清楚指出某件事為甚麼發生的確切原因****

5. ****specific example — 具體例子****

Practice 1

> Can you give me a ****specific example****?

你可以給我一個****具體例子****嗎？

Practice 2

> Use a ****specific example**** to support your point.

用一個****具體例子****支持你的觀點。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specific example = 清楚指出一個真實或確切例子的例證****

6. ****specific (特定的；某一個明確的) — 特定的****

A second major adjective branch.

Practice 1

> I'm looking for a ****specific file****.

我在找一個****特定的檔案****。

Practice 2

> She asked to speak to a ****specific person****.

她要求和一位****特定的人****談話。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specific = 指某一個明確的人、物、地方或情況，而不是泛指整類****

7. ****specific person / place / time — 特定人物 / 地點 / 時間****

Practice 1

> Do you have a **specific date** in mind?

你心目中有沒有一個**特定日期**？

Practice 2

> The rule applies only to **specific situations**.

這項規則只適用於**特定情況**。

MCQ-ready definition:

specific X = 從較大範圍中清楚指明的一個 X

8. **a specific type / kind** — 特定類型

Practice 1

> This tool is designed for a **specific type of task**.

這個工具是為一種**特定類型的任務**而設。

Practice 2

> The disease affects a **specific type of cell**.

這種疾病影響一種**特定類型的細胞**。

MCQ-ready definition:

specific type/kind = 某一個明確而限定的類別

9. **specific to** — 特有於；只適用於

A very important construction.

Practice 1

> This problem is **specific to this system**.

這個問題是這個系統**特有的**。

Practice 2

> The rule is **specific to this course**.

這項規則**只適用於這個課程**。

MCQ-ready definition:

specific to X = 只與 X 有關、只出現在 X，或只適用於 X

10. **task-specific / job-specific — 任務專用的 / 職位特定的**

Practice 1

> Employees receive **job-specific training**.

員工會接受**針對職位的專門培訓**。

Practice 2

> The software includes several **task-specific tools**.

軟件包含幾個**針對特定任務的工具**。

MCQ-ready definition:

X-specific = 專門針對 X 而設計、使用或適用的

11. **species-specific — 物種特有的**

Practice 1

> Some behaviours are **species-specific**.

有些行為是某些物種**特有的**。

Practice 2

> The response may be **species-specific**.

這種反應可能只出現在**特定物種**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****species-specific = 只出現在某一物種或只適用於某一物種的****

12. ****specifically (具體地 ; 明確地) — 具體地 ; 明確地****

Practice 1

> He ****specifically apologised**** for embarrassing me in front of the group.

他****明確地****為當眾令我難堪而道歉。

Practice 2

> Please explain ****specifically**** what went wrong.

請****具體說明****哪裏出了問題。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specifically = 以清楚而確切的方式，不含糊地****

13. ****specifically (特別地 ; 尤其) — 特別是 ; 尤其****

A major adverb sense.

Practice 1

> I was ****specifically interested in**** the final section.

我****特別有興趣****的是最後一部分。

Practice 2

> The course is aimed ****specifically at beginners****.

這個課程****特別針對初學者****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specifically = 特別指向某一個人、群體、目的或情況****

14. ****specifically designed for — 專門為.....設計****

Practice 1

> The programme was **specifically designed for new students**.

這個計劃是**專門為新生設計的**。

Practice 2

> These exercises are **specifically designed to improve fluency**.

這些練習是**專門為提升流利度而設計的**。

MCQ-ready definition:

specifically designed for X = 特別以 X 為對象或目的而設計

15. **specifically mention — 明確提到**

Practice 1

> He **specifically mentioned** the public criticism.

他**特別明確提到**那次公開批評。

Practice 2

> The instructions **specifically mention** the deadline.

說明中**明確提到**截止日期。

MCQ-ready definition:

specifically mention X = 清楚而直接地點名提及 X

16. **more specifically — 更具體地說**

A useful discourse phrase.

Practice 1

> The problem was communication—or, **more specifically**, a misunderstanding about the file.

問題出在溝通，**更具體地說**，是對檔案的一場誤會。

Practice 2

> We need better planning, **more specifically**, clearer deadlines.

我們需要更好的規劃，**更具體來說**，就是更清楚的截止日期。

MCQ-ready definition:

more specifically = 用來進一步收窄範圍並提供更精確的說明

17. **specifics (具體細節；詳情) — 具體內容；細節**

Plural noun.

Practice 1

> We haven't discussed the **specifics** yet.

我們還未討論**具體細節**。

Practice 2

> Let's talk about the **specifics** of the plan.

我們談談計劃的**具體內容**吧。

MCQ-ready definition:

the specifics = 某件事情的精確細節，而不是整體概念

18. **get into the specifics — 深入談具體細節**

Practice 1

> We can **get into the specifics** later.

我們稍後可以再**深入談細節**。

Practice 2

> Before deciding, let's **get into the specifics**.

作決定前，我們先**具體看看細節**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****get into the specifics = 開始仔細討論確切細節****

19. ****specificity (具體性；明確性) — 具體程度；精確度****

Practice 1

> The apology lacked ****specificity****.

那次道歉缺乏****具體性****。

Practice 2

> Greater ****specificity**** makes the instructions easier to follow.

更高的****明確程度****令說明更容易遵循。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specificity = 表達或資訊有多具體、精確和清楚的程度****

20. ****specificity (醫學 / 檢測：特異性) — 特異性****

A major technical sense.

Practice 1

> The test has high ****specificity****.

這項檢測有很高的****特異性****。

Practice 2

> Doctors consider both sensitivity and ****specificity****.

醫生會同時考慮敏感度和****特異性****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specificity = 在診斷檢測中，正確辨認沒有某種疾病 / 狀況者的能力****

This is an established technical meaning and distinct from ordinary 「具體性」.

21. **specificity** (生物 / 化學 : 專一性) — 專一性

Practice 1

> The enzyme shows high **specificity** for this molecule.

這種酵素對該分子具有很高的**專一性**。

Practice 2

> Receptor **specificity** affects which molecules can bind.

受體的**專一性**會影響哪些分子可以結合。

MCQ-ready definition:

specificity = 生物或化學系統只對某些特定目標產生反應或結合的程度

22. **nonspecific / non-specific** — 非特定的 ; 籠統的

Important opposite/contrast.

Practice 1

> His answer was vague and **nonspecific**.

他的答案很含糊而且**不具體**。

Practice 2

> The patient reported **nonspecific symptoms**.

病人表示出現一些**非特異性症狀**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nonspecific = 沒有指向某一明確原因、對象或類別的

23. **nonspecific symptoms** — 非特異性症狀

Practice 1

> Tiredness can be a **nonspecific symptom**.

疲倦可能是一種**非特異性症狀**。

Practice 2

> The early signs were **nonspecific**.

早期徵狀**沒有特定指向性**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nonspecific symptom = 可由很多不同原因造成，因此不能單靠它判斷某一特定疾病的症狀****

24. ****specify (明確指出；指定) — 指明；說明清楚****

A major family verb.

Practice 1

> Please ****specify the exact date****.

請****明確指出確實日期****。

Practice 2

> The form asks you to ****specify your preferred time****.

表格要求你****指定偏好的時間****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specify = 清楚而準確地指出或說明某個要求、內容或選項****

25. ****specify that... — 明確規定 / 指出.....****

Practice 1

> The rules ****specify that all files must be uploaded by Friday****.

規則****明確規定****所有檔案必須在星期五前上傳。

Practice 2

> The contract ****specifies that payment is due within thirty days****.

合約**明確寫明**款項須於三十日內支付。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specify that... = 正式而明確地說明某個規則、條件或事實****

26. ****specified (指定的 ; 已明確說明的) — 指定的****

Practice 1

> Submit the file by the ****specified deadline****.

在****指定截止日期****前提交檔案。

Practice 2

> The device must operate within the ****specified range****.

裝置必須在****指定範圍****內運作。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specified = 已經被清楚指出或設定的****

27. ****specification (詳細要求 ; 規格) — 規格 ; 詳細要求****

Practice 1

> The product meets the required ****specifications****.

產品符合所需****規格****。

Practice 2

> Read the technical ****specifications**** before buying the device.

購買裝置前先閱讀技術****規格****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****specification = 對產品、系統或工作所需特徵、尺寸、性能等作出的詳細正式說明****

28. **technical specifications** — 技術規格

Practice 1

> The website lists the laptop's **technical specifications**.

網站列出了手提電腦的**技術規格**。

Practice 2

> Check whether the machine meets the **technical specifications**.

檢查機器是否符合**技術規格**。

MCQ-ready definition:

technical specifications = 產品或系統的詳細技術要求和性能資料

29. **meet specifications** — 符合規格

Practice 1

> The material does not **meet the specifications**.

這種材料**不符合規格**。

Practice 2

> Every unit is tested to ensure it **meets specification**.

每個單位都會接受測試，以確保**符合規格要求**。

MCQ-ready definition:

meet specifications = 符合正式列明的技術或品質要求

Important distinction 1: **specific vs general**

specific

narrow, exact, clearly identified.

general

broad, not limited to one exact case.

> specific reason

> 具體原因

> general reason

> 一般原因

Important distinction 2: **specific vs particular**

Very important because they overlap.

specific

emphasizes **precision and exact identification**.

particular

often emphasizes **one member or case singled out from others**.

> I need a specific answer.

> 我需要一個**具體明確的答案**。

> I was thinking of one particular person.

> 我想到的是**某一個特定的人**。

They overlap heavily in “特定的,” but **specific** more strongly suggests exactness.

Important distinction 3: **specific vs exact**

specific

clear and detailed.

exact

completely precise/correct, with no approximation.

> specific time

> 特定時間

> exact time

> 確實時間，例如 3:17

Something can be specific without being mathematically exact.

Important distinction 4: **specific vs detailed**

specific

clearly identifies exact points.

detailed

contains many pieces of information.

An answer can be detailed but still not specific if it contains lots of irrelevant information.

Important distinction 5: **specific vs clear**

clear

easy to understand.

specific

precise and non-general.

> “Do better next time.”

> clear, but not very specific.

> “Check the shared folder before blaming someone.”

> clear **and specific**.

Important distinction 6: **specific vs precise**

specific

identifies exactly what is being referred to.

precise

accurate to a fine degree.

> a specific issue

> 某個特定問題

> a precise measurement

> 精確測量

They overlap but are not interchangeable everywhere.

Important distinction 7: **specific vs concrete**

specific

exactly identified.

concrete

tangible or clearly grounded rather than abstract.

> specific feedback

> 具體明確的回饋

> concrete evidence

> 實質證據

Important distinction 8: **specifically vs especially**

specifically

particularly and explicitly focused on one thing.

especially

particularly more than others.

> He specifically apologized for embarrassing me.

> 他**明確針對**令我難堪這件事道歉。

> I especially appreciated that part.

> 我**特別欣賞**那一點。

Subtle but important.

Important distinction 9: **specifically vs particularly**

They often overlap.

specifically

more exact/explicit.

particularly

emphasizes one thing as notable or important.

> specifically designed for beginners

> 專門為初學者設計

> particularly useful for beginners

> 對初學者尤其有用

Important distinction 10: **specific to vs specific for**

specific to X

characteristic of / limited to X.

> a problem specific to this system

這個系統特有的問題

specific for X

possible in some technical contexts, often meaning selective toward X, but for general learners **specific to** is the safer pattern for “特有於”.

Important distinction 11: **the specifics vs details**

details

general individual pieces of information.

specifics

the exact particulars needed to define the matter clearly.

> Tell me the details.

> 告訴我細節。

> Let's discuss the specifics.

> 我們談談**具體安排 / 具體內容**。

Important distinction 12: **specificity ordinary vs medical**

Ordinary

specificity = 具體性 / 明確性

Diagnostic testing

specificity = 特異性

Same noun, completely different technical mapping.

Important distinction 13: **specificity vs sensitivity in testing**

sensitivity

ability to correctly identify people who **have** the condition.

specificity

ability to correctly identify people who **do not have** the condition.

This is a major technical contrast.

Important distinction 14: **nonspecific does not mean meaningless**

nonspecific symptom

may be real and important, but it does not point uniquely to one condition.

So:

> nonspecific ≠ unimportant

Important distinction 15: **specify vs mention**

mention

refer to something briefly.

specify

state it clearly and precisely.

> He mentioned the deadline.

他提到截止日期。

> He specified the deadline as Friday at 5 p.m.

他明確指定截止時間為星期五下午五時。

Important distinction 16: **specification vs instruction**

specification

describes required properties/standards.

instruction

tells you what to do.

> product specification

> 產品規格

> installation instructions

> 安裝說明

Family-extension note

The **specific** family has several strong modern branches:

1. **exact / concrete**

- * specific reason
- * specific details
- * be specific

2. **particular / limited**

- * specific person
- * specific situation
- * specific to

3. **focused purpose**

- * specifically designed for
- * task-specific

4. **exact details**

- * the specifics
- * specificity

5. **technical selectivity**

- * medical specificity
- * biological specificity

6. **opposite**

- * nonspecific

7. **verb and noun family**

- * specify
- * specified
- * specification

For your passage, the key meaning is:

specific apology = an apology that names exactly what the person did wrong and why it hurt

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
-----	-----	-----
specific (exact)	具體的；明確的	precise, not vague
be specific	說具體一點	give exact details
specific detail	具體細節	exact information
specific reason	具體原因	exact cause
specific example	具體例子	exact illustration
specific (particular)	特定的	one clearly identified
specific person	特定人物	exact person
specific situation	特定情況	limited case
specific to X	X 特有的 / 只適用於 X	limited to X
task-specific	任務專用的	targeted use
species-specific	物種特有的	biological limitation
specifically	具體地；明確地	exact manner
specifically (especially)	特別地；專門地	focused target
specifically designed for	專門為.....設計	purpose
specifically mention	明確提到	explicit mention
more specifically	更具體地說	narrow down
the specifics	具體細節	exact particulars
specificity	具體性；明確性	degree of precision
specificity (medical)	特異性	diagnostic accuracy
specificity (biology)	專一性	selective reaction
nonspecific	非特定的；籠統的	not narrowly targeted
nonspecific symptom	非特異性症狀	many possible causes
specify	指明；明確說明	state precisely
specified	指定的	clearly stated
specification	規格；詳細要求	formal requirements
technical specifications	技術規格	product/system details

For your original sentence

> Of course, an apology does not erase everything overnight, but when it is honest, timely, and ****specific****, it can really mend the situation.

Here:

****specific = 道歉不是籠統地說一句「sorry」，而是清楚指出自己究竟做錯了甚麼，以及為甚麼那件事傷害了對方****

Kevin's apology was specific because he acknowledged:

* he had **jumped to conclusions**,
* he had let stress affect his judgment,
* and he had **embarrassed the speaker in front of the group**.

So a vague apology would be:

> “Sorry about everything.”

A specific apology would identify:

> “I'm sorry I blamed you without checking the file properly and embarrassed you in front of everyone.”

That is why a natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 只要道歉是真誠、及時而且**具體明確**的，就真的可以修補局面。

The cleanest MCQ-ready contextual meaning is:

specific = clearly stating the exact action, problem, or reason rather than being vague — 具體而明確地指出確切行為、問題或原因